

artificially colour-bright. The white balance is spot on, though—as was the case with the Premier 6370 and 5370. Overall, good image detailing, and minimal pixelation.

Among the trio of big brands, the Nikon Coolpix L4 produced the most neutral-looking results (great white balance). In fact, the L-4 produced the most neutral-looking image across the sub-8,500 rupee board. But the Premier 6370 and 5370 produced slightly more realistic-looking colours; kudos all round to Premier! Nonetheless, the detailing on the Coolpix L4 was good.

Sony's DSC S-40 produces slightly over-rich images that look a touch too bright to be termed truly natural. The S-40 also produces a yellowish-looking image with white balance set to Auto. This just proves that different manufacturers use different methods to calculate the amount of white balancing required in a scene. Of course, with a little tinkering around, and setting the white balance to "Incandescent", we were able to get rid of the yellowish tinge. The Olympus FE-115



Premier DC-5370
An unassuming performer from a new market player

came somewhat in between the Sony and the Nikon as far as white balancing goes. Shot quality-wise, we noticed that the FE-115 didn't produce highlights (on the glass and metal surfaces) quite as well as the Sony, Premier (DC-5370 / 6370 only), Techcom and Nikon models, and also suffers from the "over-bright colour" syndrome.

Bringing up the rear in this price category, we have the cheapest of the cameras—the Premier DS-3088S. Sure, we agree Premier priced this one judiciously, but it's basically on par with cell phone cameras; some of the newer camera phones from Sony Ericsson and Nokia will put it to shame. There was noticeable pixelation upon scrutiny, and it lacked crispness of colour—overall, rather drab-looking results. The DS-5082 was a bit better, with much accurate colour representation, but it, too, lost out big time on detail. Both these, the cheapest of the cameras on display, offered sub-par results—overall, not worthy of much wordspace.

Mid-Range Cameras

Two cameras fought it out for top position here; these were also incidentally the best-looking cameras. The Sony DSC L-1 and the Nikon S5 prove that beauties can have brains, or in this case, brawn! The L-1, in typical Sony style, produced a sharp image, though there was a slight yellowish tinge; adjusting the white balance quickly remedied this. This camera also produced vivid detailing with good specular effects—for example, the play of light on the glass bottle was caught nicely. We liked the

Jargon Buster

The key to making a good purchase for any product is information, holds true for Digital Cameras as well! Too many of us buy a digital camera only to find out a little too late that something better was available. The best buyer is an informed one. If you've taken the plunge and got that shiny new shooter, this little list will demystify all those tech terms flying around, and should enable you to understand the most basic settings on your camera.

Pixel

Before getting into millions of pixels i.e. megapixels, let's see what a pixel is. The word "pixel" stands for Picture Element. What you see on your digital screens—be it your PC monitor or the LCD viewfinder of your camera or even a cell phone—is basically a bunch of pixels. A general rule of thumb is that the greater the pixel count, the better and sharper the image. A greater pixel count means the image can be viewed at its native resolution, that is, the resolution it was captured at, with less loss in visual detail.

Megapixel

The megapixel (MP) rating of a camera represents the resolution (in millions of pixels) that the camera is capable of producing. A 6-megapixel camera's CCD sensor would be capable of capturing an image containing up to approximately 6 million pixels.

Sensor

The digital image on your digicam is produced by the camera's sensor. The sensor is basically a unit that measures the brightness

of each pixel. The sensor unit consists of millions of tiny pixels arranged in an array-like fashion. Each pixel is tasked with capturing photons, and each pixel can capture a certain number of them. The photons collected by each pixel are converted into an electrical charge via a Photodiode. After this, the electrical charge needs to be amplified, and then converted to a digital value—which is done by the ADC (Analogue to Digital Converter).

CCD & CMOS

Digital camera sensors are of two types. The most common are CCD (Charge-Coupled Device) sensors, used in nearly all cameras, and CMOS (Complementary Metal-Oxide Semiconductor). CMOS sensors are relatively faster and smaller than their CCD counterparts, and are found only on some select high-end cameras.

Optical and Digital Zoom

It's simple: Optical = good, Digital = not so good! In brief, optical zoom uses the camera optics, that is, the lens, to bring the subject in focus closer. This is the actual way a zoom should work, and even film cameras used this sort of zoom. Digital zoom is "simulated" zoom: the sensor crops the image and then enlarges the cropped portion to the size of the original; this is called interpolation, and results in image quality loss. Digital zooming thus has nothing to do with camera optics.

Pixelation

This refers to the graininess you sometimes see in an image, and can be caused by either a weak pixel fill rate, improper geometry of the individual pixels, or other factors such as colour accuracy,